

WATER VAPOR

Most of the water on the planet probably erupted from huge volcanoes early in Earth's history. Volcanoes still produce a lot of water vapor, as well as other gases. A similar mixture would have formed Earth's first atmosphere. The water vapor turned into clouds that spilled torrential rain on the bare rocky surface of Earth's crust, flooding it to form the first oceans.

WOW!

Some ocean water may have arrived on Earth in the form of icy comets that melted as they plunged through the planet's atmosphere.



THE GLOBAL OCEAN

Four billion years ago, there were no continents at all, and Earth had only a thin crust of the basalt that now forms the ocean floors. So the first ocean probably covered the whole planet. Over time, volcanoes created the lighter rocks that formed the first continents. As these land masses grew, the water flowed into the low-lying basins between them to fill deep oceans like those we see today.